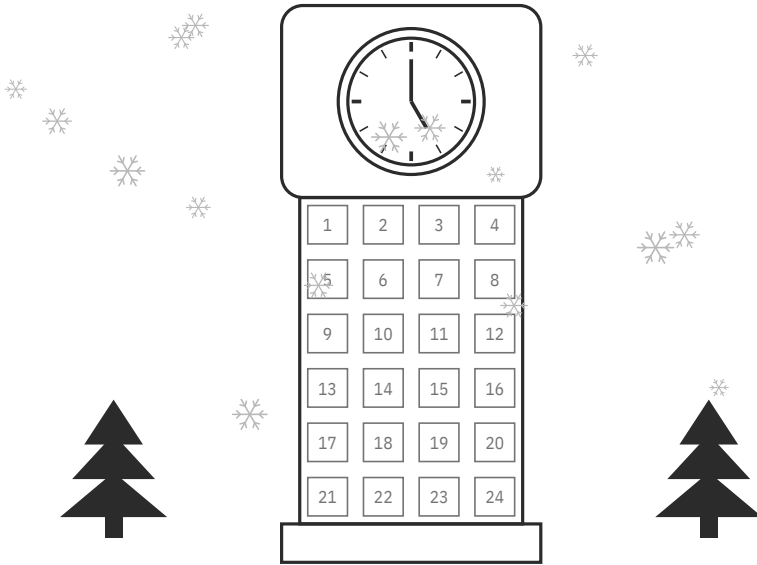


A CHRISTMAS PUZZLE COUNTDOWN

THE ADVENT CLOCK

24 doors, 24 puzzles and one hidden star



Blake La Pierre

The Advent Clock: A Christmas Puzzle Countdown

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This is a work of fiction. Snowberry Lodge, its guests and its clock are imaginary, and any resemblance to real places or people is coincidental.

First edition, 2026

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THE ADVENT CLOCK

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SNOWBERRY LODGE, DECEMBER

THE GREAT ADVENT CLOCK



Every December since 1926, the Great Advent Clock has stood in the lobby of the Snowberry Lodge, between the fireplace and the stairs: a tall case of dark walnut with a painted moon on its face and, below the face, twenty-four little doors, each no bigger than a playing card.

It was built by the village clockmaker, Barnaby Thrush, and it has been looked after ever since by his granddaughter, Mrs. Otilie Thrush, who is eighty-one, wears three cardigans at once, and knows more about puzzles than anyone on the mountain.

The tradition is simple. On the first of December Otilie hides the lodge's silver star, the one that goes on top of the great tree in the lobby, and the twenty-four little doors hold the clues to where it is. Each door has a tiny brass dial of letters. Dial the right word and the door springs open.

This year Otilie has gone to spend Christmas with her sister by the sea. She has left the manager, Mr. Humphrey Budd, a sealed envelope, a notebook of twenty-four puzzles, and strict instructions: *one door a day, no peeking, and the star goes on the tree at midnight on Christmas Eve.*

Mr. Budd, who is round and kind and hopeless at puzzles, has handed the notebook to you. His niece Winnie, fifteen and never without her detective's notebook, has appointed herself your assistant. Nobody has dared to argue.

FOUND IN THE ENVELOPE

A LETTER



My dear puzzler,

Behind the doors of my grandfather's clock you will find twenty-four puzzles, one for every day of Advent. Each one hides a single word. Dial it, and the door will open.

*Each word also gives you one letter, its **key letter**, which I have marked. Keep all twenty-four safe in the Door Log. On Christmas Eve they will tell you where I have hidden the star.*

Take your time, drink plenty of cocoa, and don't let Humphrey near the gingerbread.

With love and a merry Christmas,

Ottilie Thrush

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

HOW THIS BOOK WORKS



- * **One door a day.** Each door has two facing pages: a short scene and the rules on the left, the puzzle on the right. You can of course go at your own speed; the puzzles do not depend on each other until Christmas Eve.
- * **Find the word.** Every puzzle leads to exactly one answer word. The rules tell you how to read it out of the finished puzzle. Write it in the answer boxes.
- * **Keep the key letter.** One answer box is drawn with a heavy border and a small key. That is the day's **key letter**. Copy it into the Door Log on page 7.
- * **Stuck?** Every door has three hints at the back of the book, in three separate sections so you only see as much as you want: a **Nudge**, a **Foothold** and a **Last Step**. Full solutions come after the hints.
- * **Checked by computer.** Every grid puzzle in this book was re-solved by a separate computer program to make sure it has exactly one solution, and every answer was checked letter by letter.
- * **You will need** a pencil, an eraser, and on one or two days a little patience. No phone, app or internet is needed.

KEEP YOUR KEY LETTERS HERE

THE DOOR LOG



DOOR	ANSWER	KEY LETTER
1 <i>Dec 1</i>	_____	☐
2 <i>Dec 2</i>	_____	☐
3 <i>Dec 3</i>	_____	☐
4 <i>Dec 4</i>	_____	☐
5 <i>Dec 5</i>	_____	☐
6 <i>Dec 6</i>	_____	☐
7 <i>Dec 7</i>	_____	☐
8 <i>Dec 8</i>	_____	☐
9 <i>Dec 9</i>	_____	☐
10 <i>Dec 10</i>	_____	☐
11 <i>Dec 11</i>	_____	☐
12 <i>Dec 12</i>	_____	☐
13 <i>Dec 13</i>	_____	☐
14 <i>Dec 14</i>	_____	☐
15 <i>Dec 15</i>	_____	☐
16 <i>Dec 16</i>	_____	☐
17 <i>Dec 17</i>	_____	☐
18 <i>Dec 18</i>	_____	☐
19 <i>Dec 19</i>	_____	☐
20 <i>Dec 20</i>	_____	☐
21 <i>Dec 21</i>	_____	☐
22 <i>Dec 22</i>	_____	☐
23 <i>Dec 23</i>	_____	☐
24 <i>Dec 24</i>	_____	☐

DECEMBER 1 · DOOR ONE

THE FIRST DOOR



Ottillie's notebook is bound in green cloth and smells of pine needles. The first page says only: *Start with something easy. Everybody deserves a warm-up.* Winnie reads it over your shoulder, sharpens two pencils, and hands you one. Outside, the first proper snow of the winter is settling on the car park, and in the kitchen someone is already melting chocolate. Door One is the lowest on the left, with a sprig of painted holly around its keyhole.

HOW TO SOLVE

Find every word from the list in the grid. Words run across, down or diagonally down-right, and they may share letters. When all the words are found, read the letters that were not used, row by row from the top left. They spell a short message.

YOUR ANSWER

--	--	--	--	--	--

KEY

The heavy box is today's key letter. Copy it into the Door Log (page 7).

Hints: pages 59, 61 and 63 · Solution: page 65

DOOR ONE*December 1*

S	T	A	R	T	H	S	E
K	S	C	A	R	F	A	E
M	I	T	T	E	N	N	Y
R	S	C	N	O	R	T	H
O	O	S	A	G	I	A	S
B	C	L	N	N	I	T	I
I	K	E	N	O	D	F	S
N	S	D	E	L	W	Y	T

- ☐ CANDY
- ☐ GIFT
- ☐ MITTEN
- ☐ NORTH

- ☐ ROBIN
- ☐ SANTA
- ☐ SCARF
- ☐ SLED

- ☐ SNOW
- ☐ SOCKS
- ☐ STAR

DECEMBER 2 · DOOR TWO

A SECRET MESSAGE



Behind the first door you found a tiny wooden sleigh, painted red. Today the notebook holds a line of nonsense letters and a note: *Grandfather liked to move things along a little. Every letter here has taken the same number of steps along the alphabet, fewer than five.* Winnie is certain it is a code used by Roman generals. Mr. Budd is certain it is a shopping list. They are both a little bit right.

HOW TO SOLVE

Each letter of the message has been shifted forward along the alphabet by the same number of steps (after Z comes A again). Shift every letter back by that number to read the message. Try each number from 1 to 4 on the first word: only one gives English.

YOUR ANSWER



KEY

The heavy box is today's key letter. Copy it into the Door Log (page 7).

Hints: pages 59, 61 and 63 · Solution: page 66

DOOR TWO

December 2

K D Q J W K H J U H H Q

O H D Y H V D Q G U H G

E H U U L H V D E R Y H

H Y H U B G R R U .

W K H N H B L V

K R O O B .

ALPHABET STRIP (WRITE THE SHIFTED LETTERS UNDERNEATH IF IT HELPS)

A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H	I	J	K	L	M
N	O	P	Q	R	S	T	U	V	W	X	Y	Z

DECEMBER 3 · DOOR THREE

STARS IN THE GARDEN



The lodge garden is a patchwork of flowerbeds under the snow, and Otilie has drawn a map of them in the notebook: six beds, oddly shaped, fitted together like a quilt. *Every spring I plant one silver star in each bed, she writes, and in each row and each column, and never two side by side, because stars need room to shine.*

HOW TO SOLVE

Place six stars in the grid: exactly one in each row, one in each column and one in each outlined region. No two stars may touch, not even diagonally. When all the stars are placed, read the small letters under them, row by row from the top.

YOUR ANSWER



KEY

The heavy box is today's key letter. Copy it into the Door Log (page 7).

Hints: pages 59, 61 and 63 · Solution: page 67

DOOR THREE

December 3

R	T	M	H	P	W
T	P	R	A	L	C
R	S	P	S	E	K
A	U	S	Y	B	W
H	Y	T	T	B	L
H	H	T	T	A	E

DECEMBER 4 · DOOR FOUR

THE SLEIGH PUZZLE



In the old stables behind the lodge stands the sleigh that used to carry guests up from the village before the railway came. Its seat is carved with a square of letters, and some of the letters have worn away. Winnie brushes off the snow and copies what is left into the notebook. *Six letters, she says, and they're all in every row.*

HOW TO SOLVE

Fill the grid so that every row, every column and every 2×3 box contains each of the six letters E, G, H, I, L, S exactly once. Then read the letters in the numbered cells, in number order: 1, 2, 3 and so on.

YOUR ANSWER

--	--	--	--	--	--

KEY

The heavy box is today's key letter. Copy it into the Door Log (page 7).

Hints: pages 59, 61 and 63 · Solution: page 68

DOOR FOUR

December 4

H	E		2		G
I			S	H	3
	6	E	5		
	I	G	E	L	
E	1	I			
			4		S

DECEMBER 5 · DOOR FIVE

THE TOBOGGAN RUN



On the fifth morning the snow is perfect, and half the lodge is out on the hill with toboggans. Otilie's puzzle is a map of the old run through the pine wood, which twists back on itself so often that Mr. Budd once got lost on it for an entire afternoon. *Keep to the path, the note says, and collect the letters as you go.*

HOW TO SOLVE

Find the way through the maze from the entrance at the top left to the exit at the bottom right. There is only one route. Some squares hold letters: the ones on your route, read in the order you pass them, spell the answer. Letters off the route are decoys.

YOUR ANSWER

--	--	--	--	--	--	--	--

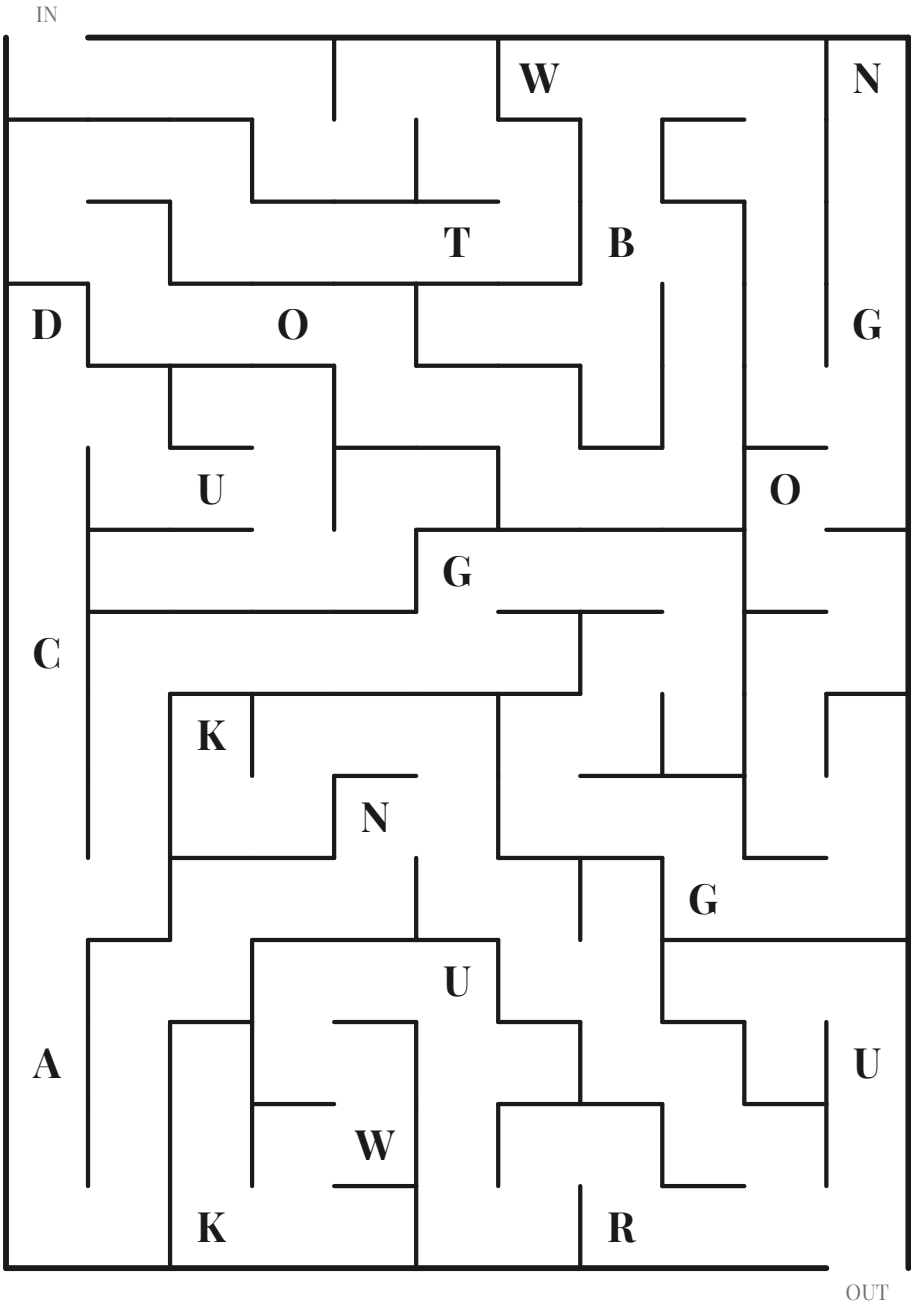
KEY

The heavy box is today's key letter. Copy it into the Door Log (page 7).

Hints: pages 59, 61 and 63 · Solution: page 69

DOOR FIVE

December 5



DECEMBER 6 · DOOR SIX

A PICTURE IN THE DARK



A storm brings the power lines down, and the lodge spends the evening by firelight. Mr. Budd hands round blankets; somebody starts a sing-song in the lounge. Winnie holds a flashlight while you open the notebook to a page of numbers with no picture at all. *Shade the right squares*, Otilie has written, *and you will see what we need tonight*.

HOW TO SOLVE

Shade some squares of the grid to reveal a picture. The numbers beside each row and above each column give the lengths of the runs of shaded squares in that line, in order, with at least one blank square between runs. The picture names the answer.

YOUR ANSWER



KEY

The heavy box is today's key letter. Copy it into the Door Log (page 7).

Hints: pages 59, 61 and 63 · Solution: page 70

19

DECEMBER 7 · DOOR SEVEN

THE SNOWBALL STACK



The annual snowball-building contest is held on the front lawn. The rule is ancient and very strict: every snowball in a stack must weigh exactly as much as the two it sits on. Otilie has drawn last year's winning stack, with most of the numbers rubbed out, and a line at the bottom: $A = 1, B = 2 \dots Z = 26$.

HOW TO SOLVE

Each brick in the pyramid holds the sum of the two bricks directly below it. Work out every number. Then turn the five numbers in the bottom row into letters with $A = 1, B = 2$, and so on up to $Z = 26$, and read them from left to right.

YOUR ANSWER

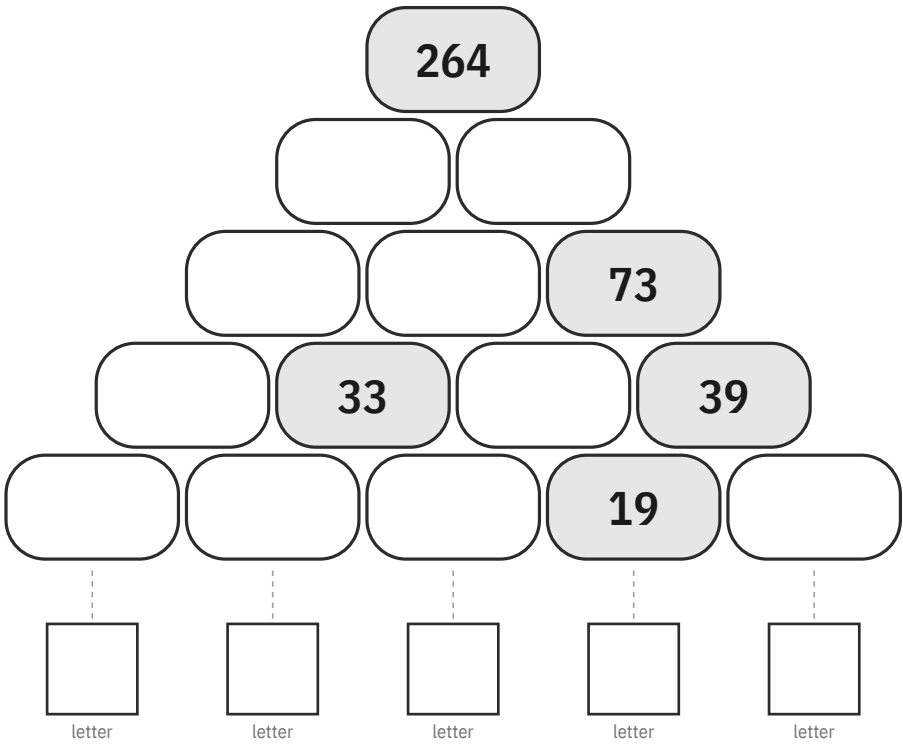


KEY

The heavy box is today's key letter. Copy it into the Door Log (page 7).

Hints: pages 59, 61 and 63 · Solution: page 71

DOOR SEVEN

December 7

DECEMBER 8 · DOOR EIGHT

THE PIGPEN CODE



Winnie has discovered that the old pantry door is covered, at knee height, in strange scratched symbols: little corners, boxes and arrows, some with dots. The cook says they have always been there. The notebook says: *Grandfather's favourite code. It fits in a noughts-and-crosses grid, and it has kept the pantry secret for a hundred years.*

HOW TO SOLVE

Each symbol stands for one letter. The key shows how: a letter is drawn as the shape of the part of the grid it sits in, with a dot if it comes from a dotted grid. Decode the message, one symbol at a time.

YOUR ANSWER



KEY

The heavy box is today's key letter. Copy it into the Door Log (page 7).

Hints: pages 59, 61 and 63 · Solution: page 72

DOOR EIGHT

December 8

A	B	C	J •	K •	L •		
D	E	F	M •	N •	O •		
G	H	I	P •	Q •	R •		

THE KEY

[illegible]

DECEMBER 9 · DOOR NINE

FIVE SKATERS



Five guests from the corridor on the second floor have gone skating on the frozen lake, and they have all left their mugs of cocoa on the windowsill of the boathouse. The notebook sets you a proper old-fashioned logic puzzle about them. *When you know who sleeps where, writes Otilie, walk down the corridor from Room 1 and say their names.*

HOW TO SOLVE

Rooms 1 to 5 are in a row along the corridor, from left to right. Each of the five guests has a different room, a different topping on their cocoa and has knitted a different thing. Use the clues and the chart to match everything up. Then read the first letters of the guests' names in room order, 1 to 5.

YOUR ANSWER

--	--	--	--	--

KEY

The heavy box is today's key letter. Copy it into the Door Log (page 7).

Hints: pages 59, 61 and 63 · Solution: page 73

DOOR NINE

December 9

- 1. Sam is not in Room 4.
- 2. Ada did not knit the mittens.
- 3. The guest who knitted the bobble hat is in the room directly to the right of the guest who knitted the socks.
- 4. Ada did not knit the jumper.
- 5. Tom does not have cinnamon.
- 6. The guest with nutmeg on their cocoa and the guest who knitted the jumper are in neighbouring rooms.
- 7. The guest with whipped cream on their cocoa knitted the scarf.
- 8. Sam did not knit the mittens.
- 9. The guest with whipped cream on their cocoa is in a room somewhere to the left of the guest who knitted the mittens.
- 10. Kit has marshmallows on their cocoa.
- 11. The guest with cinnamon on their cocoa is in the room directly to the right of the guest who knitted the jumper.
- 12. The guest who knitted the mittens is in the room directly to the right of the guest with peppermint on their cocoa.
- 13. Ada did not knit the scarf.

	Room 1	Room 2	Room 3	Room 4	Room 5	marshm.	cinnamon	cream	pepperm.	nutmeg	scarf	mittens	hat	socks	jumper
SAM															
KIT															
ADA															
TOM															
EVE															

DECEMBER 10 · DOOR TEN

SNOWMEN AND PINES



The children of the lodge have built snowmen all over the pine grove, one for each tree, and they want a plan of it for the lodge newsletter. The snowmen are shy, apparently: they will not stand next to one another, even corner to corner. Winnie has been appointed Chief Snowman Surveyor.

HOW TO SOLVE

Place one snowman next to each pine tree, directly above, below, left or right of it. Every tree has its own snowman. No two snowmen touch, not even diagonally. The numbers show how many snowmen are in each row and column. Then read the small letters under the snowmen, row by row from the top.

YOUR ANSWER

--	--	--	--	--	--	--	--	--	--	--

KEY

The heavy box is today's key letter. Copy it into the Door Log (page 7).

Hints: pages 59, 61 and 63 · Solution: page 74

DOOR TEN

December 10

1	2	1	2	1	1	1	2	
G		I		C	O	O	O	2
F	E	O	G	D	S	W	S	0
M	I		N	N	R	G	M	2
S	E	A	S	S	T		E	1
E		F	R			D	A	1
W	A	C	T	B	B	U	R	2
B		G	H		H	Y		0
U	E	H	S	A	L		D	3

DECEMBER 11 · DOOR ELEVEN

THE LITTLE RAILWAY



The little mountain train is running late, as usual, because of the snow, and the children have built their own railway in the lobby out of cardboard. Otilie's puzzle is a tiny railway too. *Lay the line, she writes, and read the station names on the way.*

HOW TO SOLVE

Draw one continuous track that enters at A and leaves at B. The track goes through square centres, with straight pieces and curves only; it never branches or crosses itself. The numbers tell you how many squares in each row and column hold track. Some pieces are laid for you. Read the letters on the track, in order from A to B.

YOUR ANSWER



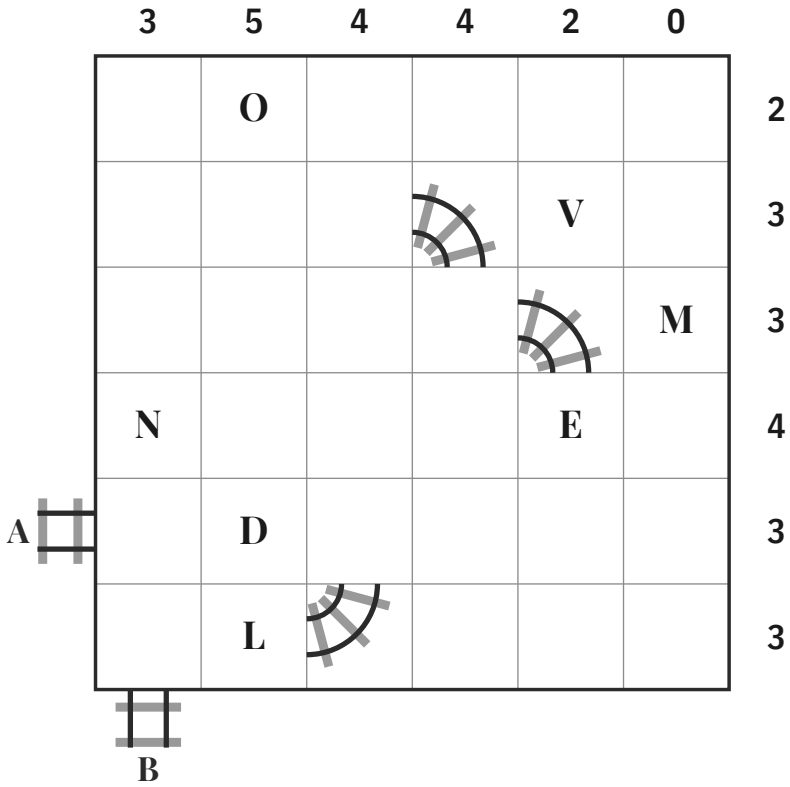
KEY

The heavy box is today's key letter. Copy it into the Door Log (page 7).

Hints: pages 59, 61 and 63 · Solution: page 75

DOOR ELEVEN

December 11



DECEMBER 12 · DOOR TWELVE

LANTERNS IN THE CELLAR

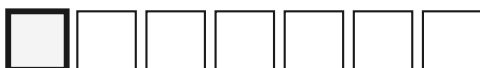


The lodge cellar is a maze of brick pillars and wine racks, and it needs lighting for the Christmas party. Every lantern lights its own square and shines along its row and column until it hits a wall. Two lanterns that can see each other dazzle each other, which Otilie will not allow.

HOW TO SOLVE

Place lanterns in some white squares so that every white square is lit. A lantern lights its square and every square in its row and column until a black block stops it. No lantern may shine on another. A number on a black block tells you how many lanterns are directly next to it (above, below, left, right). Read the letters under the lanterns, row by row from the top.

YOUR ANSWER



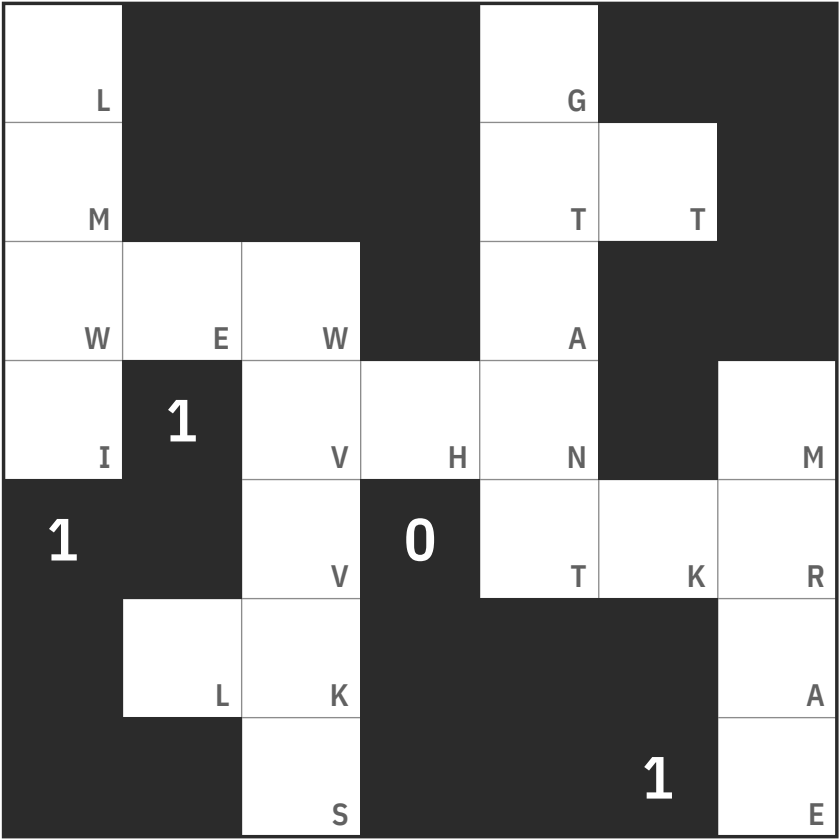
KEY

The heavy box is today's key letter. Copy it into the Door Log (page 7).

Hints: pages 59, 61 and 63 · Solution: page 76

DOOR TWELVE

December 12



DECEMBER 13 · DOOR THIRTEEN

BY THE HEARTH



The big fireplace in the lounge has a basket of logs, a basket of knitting, and today a basket of words. Otilie has left a list of Christmassy things and a blank grid, like a crossword with no clues. *Everything fits in just one way*, she writes. *And then sit by the fire for a while.*

HOW TO SOLVE

Fit every word from the list into the grid, one letter per white square, reading across or down. Each word is used once. Use the lengths and the crossing letters to decide which word goes where. Then read the letters in the numbered circles, in number order.

YOUR ANSWER



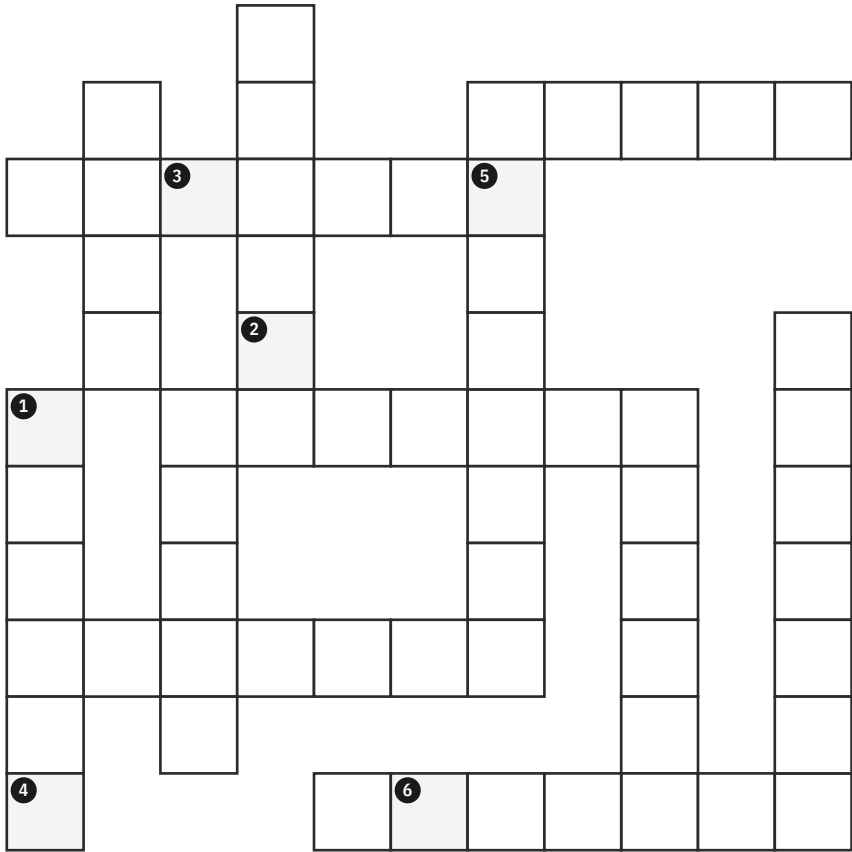
KEY

The heavy box is today's key letter. Copy it into the Door Log (page 7).

Hints: pages 59, 61 and 63 · Solution: page 77

DOOR THIRTEEN

December 13



4 LETTERS

SLED

5 LETTERS

CANDY**SCARF**

6 LETTERS

GINGER**HAMPER****RIBBON**

7 LETTERS

BLANKET**CHIMNEY****CRACKER****HOLIDAY****PUDDING**

8 LETTERS

STOCKING

DECEMBER 14 · DOOR FOURTEEN

HIDDEN PRESENTS

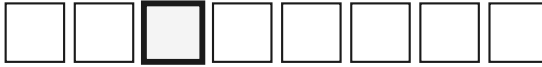


Mr. Budd has hidden presents for the staff around the storeroom, and forgotten where. All he remembers is how many presents were near each spot on the floor. Winnie rolls her eyes and fetches the notebook.

HOW TO SOLVE

Some squares hide a present. A number in a square tells you how many presents are in the up to eight squares around it (including diagonals); squares with numbers never hide a present. There are exactly 8 presents. Find them all, then read the letters in their squares, row by row from the top.

YOUR ANSWER



KEY

The heavy box is today's key letter. Copy it into the Door Log (page 7).

Hints: pages 59, 61 and 63 · Solution: page 78

DOOR FOURTEEN

December 14

2		2	2			
	P			B	O	O
R	V	E	2	S	1	R
2	E	U		R	D	1
						G
U	E	H	1	1	M	0
0	S	T		N	2	1
						B
I	P	T	R	S	S	O
C	1	1	T	1	F	0

DECEMBER 15 · DOOR FIFTEEN

THE BAUBLE TREE

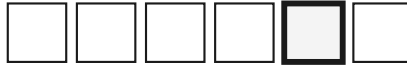


The tree in the lobby is still bare at the top, waiting for its star, but the lower branches are filling up with glass baubles from a battered old box. Each bauble has a number painted on it. Otilie's puzzle arranges them in a square and asks you to put them in order.

HOW TO SOLVE

Fill the grid with the numbers 1 to 5 so that each number appears once in every row and every column. The signs between squares point to the smaller number (< and >). Then turn the digits in the numbered cells into letters with the key, and read them in number order.

YOUR ANSWER



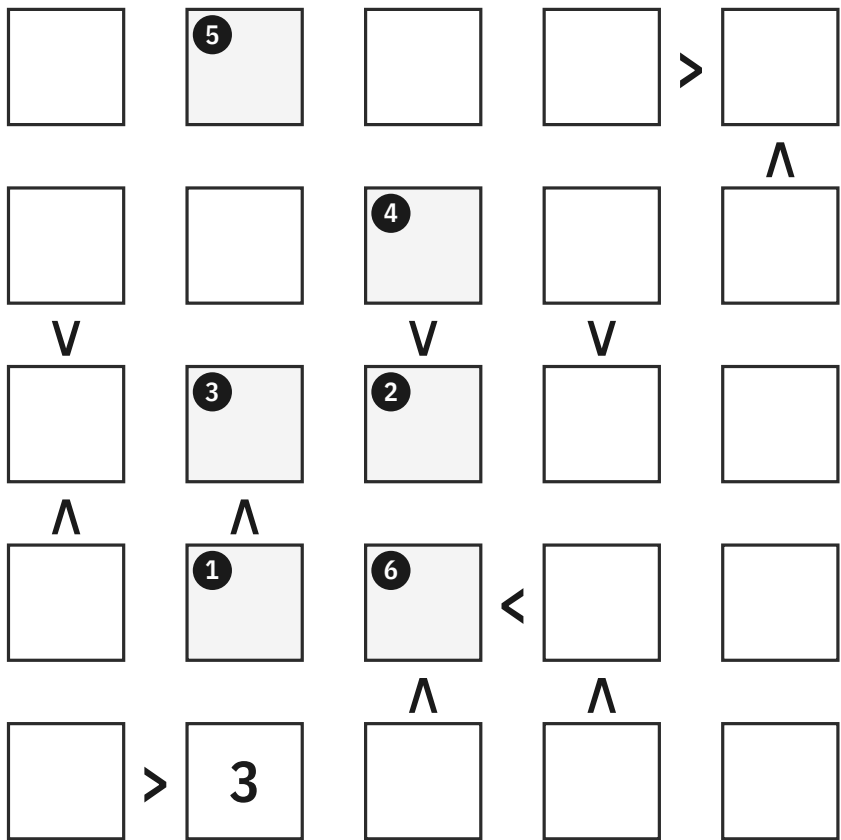
KEY

The heavy box is today's key letter. Copy it into the Door Log (page 7).

Hints: pages 59, 61 and 63 · Solution: page 79

DOOR FIFTEEN

December 15



KEY				
1	2	3	4	5
E	L	A	U	B

DECEMBER 16 · DOOR SIXTEEN

BELLS ON THE SLEIGH



On the sixteenth, the sleigh from Door Four is out on the snow again, pulled by two very patient ponies, and its bells ring out across the valley: short and long, short and long. *Listen carefully*, the notebook says, *they are telling you what goes in the cocoa tonight.*

HOW TO SOLVE

The message is written in Morse code: each letter is a group of dots (short rings) and dashes (long rings). Letters are separated by spaces and words by a slash. Use the table to decode it.

YOUR ANSWER

--	--	--	--	--	--

KEY

The heavy box is today's key letter. Copy it into the Door Log (page 7).

Hints: pages 59, 61 and 63 · Solution: page 80

DOOR SIXTEEN

December 16

- . .. - - - - . - - . /
 _ _ _ _ _ _ _ _ _ _

 - - - - . /
 _ _ _ _ _

 - - - - . - - . /
 _ _ _ _ _ _ _

 - /
 _ _ _ _

 - . - . - . - - /
 _ _ _ _ _ _ _

 /
 _ _

 . - - . - - . - . - - - - - . /
 _ _ _ _ _ _ _ _ _ _ _ _ _ _

MORSE TABLE

A	.-	B	-...	C	-.-.	D	-..
E	.	F	..-.	G	--.	H	
I	..	J	.-.-	K	-.-	L	.-..
M	--	N	-.	O	---	P	.-.-.
Q	---.	R	.-.	S	...	T	-
U	...-	V	...-	W	.-.-	X	-.-.
Y	-.--	Z	--..				

DECEMBER 17 · DOOR SEVENTEEN

THE SLEIGH FLEET



Every year on the seventeenth the whole valley holds a sleigh race, and the frozen lake becomes a car park for sleighs. Otilie has drawn a map of the lake from memory, with the sleighs parked neatly so that none of them touch, as the rules demand.

HOW TO SOLVE

Hide the fleet in the grid: one sleigh of three squares, two of two squares and three little sleds of one square. Each lies across or down. No two touch, not even diagonally. The numbers show how many squares are taken in each row and column. Some squares are marked as open snow (wavy lines) or sleigh (grey dot). Read the letters in the sleighs' squares, row by row.

YOUR ANSWER

--	--	--	--	--	--	--	--	--	--

KEY

The heavy box is today's key letter. Copy it into the Door Log (page 7).

Hints: pages 59, 61 and 63 · Solution: page 81

DOOR SEVENTEEN

December 17

1	0	4	1	0	1	3	
S	W	N	 G	D	 M	K	2
D	K	I	A	Y	O	R	1
S	W	O	V	R	U	L	0
I	T	W	F	C	R	C	2
W	P	I	P	E	S	L	1
E	P	A	I	E	U	K	2
E	N	E	N	K	D	S	2

THE FLEET: 

DECEMBER 18 · DOOR EIGHTEEN

THE LANTERN WALK



Tonight is the lantern walk through the woods, and the lobby is full of guests in boots and scarves arguing about who has the matches. Ottilie's puzzle is a bigger word search, and a trickier one. *My words hide in every direction, she warns, even backwards, like my nephew.*

HOW TO SOLVE

Find every word from the list in the grid. Words run in any of the eight directions, including backwards, and they may share letters. When all the words are found, read the letters that were not used, row by row from the top left. They spell a short message.

YOUR ANSWER



KEY

The heavy box is today's key letter. Copy it into the Door Log (page 7).

Hints: pages 59, 61 and 63 · Solution: page 82

DOOR EIGHTEEN

December 18☐ CHESTNUT☐ CINNAMON☐ COOKIE☐ CRACKER☐ FIRESIDE☐ GARLAND☐ ORNAMENT☐ PINECONE☐ SLIPPERS☐ SNOWDRIFT☐ STOCKING

DECEMBER 19 • DOOR NINETEEN

CHIMNEYS



From the top of the hill behind the lodge you can see all the chimneys of the village, puffing away. Some are tall, some are short, and the tall ones hide the short ones behind them. Otilie's puzzle is a village of chimneys seen from all four sides.

HOW TO SOLVE

Fill the grid with chimneys of height 1 to 5, each height once in every row and column. A number outside the grid tells you how many chimneys you can see from that side, looking along the row or column: a taller chimney hides every shorter one behind it. Then turn the digits in the numbered cells into letters with the key, and read them in number order.

YOUR ANSWER



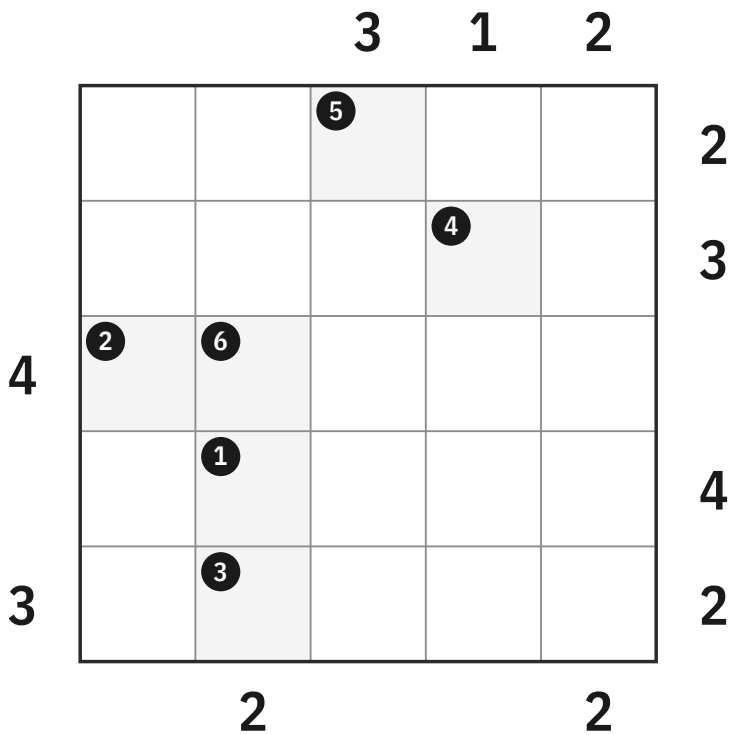
KEY

The heavy box is today's key letter. Copy it into the Door Log (page 7).

Hints: pages 59, 61 and 63 • Solution: page 83

DOOR NINETEEN

December 19



KEY

1	2	3	4	5
O	E	S	F	T

DECEMBER 20 · DOOR TWENTY

A SNOWBALL FIGHT



The great snowball fight between the kitchen staff and the guests ends, as it does every year, in a draw and hot cocoa. On the notebook page, Ottilie has drawn the battlefield: the lodge lawn, divided into eight patches, with room for one snow fort in each.

HOW TO SOLVE

Place eight stars in the grid: exactly one in each row, one in each column and one in each outlined region. No two stars may touch, not even diagonally. When all the stars are placed, read the small letters under them, row by row from the top.

YOUR ANSWER



KEY

The heavy box is today's key letter. Copy it into the Door Log (page 7).

Hints: pages 59, 61 and 63 · Solution: page 84

DOOR TWENTY

December 20

D	A	P	N	U	S	K	F
V	I	M	N	S	S	I	K
O	O	P	E	B	V	R	F
O	U	W	D	W	E	N	N
B	C	W	R	A	N	N	H
F	K	D	E	F	L	A	I
M	B	L	L	G	C	L	S
E	V	N	F	Y	C	G	L

DECEMBER 21 · DOOR TWENTY-ONE

THE BELL TOWER



At noon, the bell in the little tower above the lodge rings for the midwinter lunch, and everyone troops in from the snow. Winnie notices that it rings twenty-one times, not twelve. *Someone has been fiddling with the clockwork*, she says darkly. The notebook just has another page of numbers.

HOW TO SOLVE

Shade some squares of the grid to reveal a picture. The numbers beside each row and above each column give the lengths of the runs of shaded squares in that line, in order, with at least one blank square between runs. The picture names the answer.

YOUR ANSWER



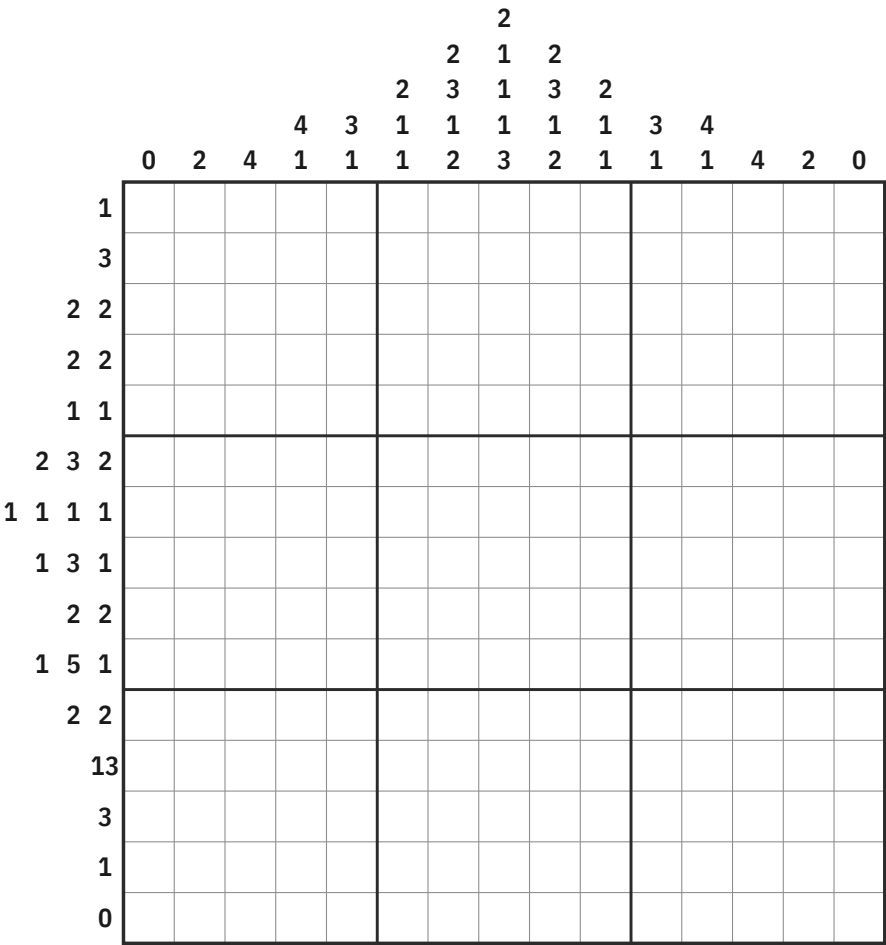
KEY

The heavy box is today's key letter. Copy it into the Door Log (page 7).

Hints: pages 59, 61 and 63 · Solution: page 85

DOOR TWENTY-ONE

December 21



DECEMBER 22 · DOOR TWENTY-TWO

COOKIE TINS



The kitchen is in full Christmas baking mode, and every surface is covered in cookie tins. Each tin has a label with a number and a little sum: the cook's own system, which nobody else understands. Winnie thinks it is a code. It is, of course, a puzzle.

HOW TO SOLVE

Fill the grid with the numbers 1 to 5 so that each number appears once in every row and every column. Each outlined tin shows a target and a sign: the numbers in the tin must make the target with that sign (+ add, $\times$ multiply, $-$ difference, $\div$ division, in any order). A tin with no sign is just that number. Then turn the digits in the numbered cells into letters with the key, and read them in number order.

YOUR ANSWER



KEY

The heavy box is today's key letter. Copy it into the Door Log (page 7).

Hints: pages 59, 61 and 63 · Solution: page 86

DOOR TWENTY-TWO

December 22

1	20×	2÷	1-	2-
				4
9+	2×		20×	5
	2-	1-		
		8+	1	

KEY				
1	2	3	4	5
M	S	R	Y	E

DECEMBER 23 · DOOR TWENTY-THREE

THE BIG BAKE



The day before Christmas Eve is the day of the Big Bake. The cook's great fruitcake has been soaking in something strong since October, and the whole lodge smells of oranges and spice. Otilie's last big puzzle is a full-size letter square, nine by nine.

HOW TO SOLVE

Fill the grid so that every row, every column and every 3×3 box contains each of the nine letters A, C, E, F, I, K, R, T, U exactly once. Then read the letters in the numbered cells, in number order.

YOUR ANSWER

--	--	--	--	--	--	--	--	--

KEY

The heavy box is today's key letter. Copy it into the Door Log (page 7).

Hints: pages 59, 61 and 63 · Solution: page 87

DOOR TWENTY-THREE

December 23

		R			A		I	U
U	4		E		R	7		T
T			I					
6	A		1		K		R	9
I		K	R			U	A	C
		T				8		I
	5				I		K	F
	K	E		2			3	
A	U	I	K	F			T	

DECEMBER 24 · DOOR TWENTY-FOUR

THE LAST LINE



Christmas Eve. The lodge is full, the snow is falling, and the tree in the lobby is covered from top to bottom, except for the very top. At four in the afternoon Mr. Budd starts pacing. At five, Winnie confiscates his cocoa. There is one door left, and one last railway to lay.

HOW TO SOLVE

Draw one continuous track that enters at A and leaves at B. The track goes through square centres, with straight pieces and curves only; it never branches or crosses itself. The numbers tell you how many squares in each row and column hold track. Some pieces are laid for you. Read the letters on the track, in order from A to B.

YOUR ANSWER



KEY

The heavy box is today's key letter. Copy it into the Door Log (page 7).

Hints: pages 59, 61 and 63 · Solution: page 88

DOOR TWENTY-FOUR

December 24

	3	4	5	3	1	4	6	1	
			M						0
	R		I						3
		H				S			5
			S		F		E		5
A 		C		T	A				6
			M		A		V		5
									1
		E	K		F		E		2
									
								B	

CHRISTMAS EVE, A QUARTER TO MIDNIGHT

THE LAST MESSAGE



All twenty-four doors are open. Behind the last one is a little card in Otilie’s handwriting: *Put each door’s key letter in the box with that door’s number, and you will know where to go.*

5	2	14	4	18	6	7			
10	9	8	11	12	13	3			
23	15	19	24	17	1	16	20	21	22

The small number under each box is a door number.

When you have read the message, turn the page.

CHRISTMAS EVE

MIDNIGHT



At a quarter to midnight the whole lodge crowds into the lobby. Winnie leads the way up the narrow stairs behind the Great Advent Clock, into the little clock tower, where the bell hangs and the clockwork ticks and whirrs. Tucked behind the great brass gearwheel, wrapped in an old green scarf, is the silver star.

Mr. Budd carries it down as if it were made of eggshell. At the first stroke of midnight Winnie climbs the ladder and sets it on the top of the tree, and the whole lobby cheers. The bell above rings twelve times, exactly as it should.

On the mantelpiece, beside the cocoa, there is a postcard from the seaside that nobody saw arrive. It says: *Well done. Merry Christmas. Same time next year?* — O.T.



A GENTLE PUSH IN THE RIGHT DIRECTION

HINTS I: NUDGES



- DOOR 1** Start with the longest words and the rare letters (K, W, Y). Cross each word off the list and lightly shade its letters.
- DOOR 2** Look at the short words: a three-letter word that appears twice is very likely THE.
- DOOR 3** Find the smallest region first: its star has only a few places to go. Then rule out every square that touches a placed star.
- DOOR 4** Look for a row, column or box that already has most of its letters. The missing letters can often go in only one place.
- DOOR 5** Try working backwards from the exit, and shade dead ends as you find them.
- DOOR 6** Start with the biggest numbers. A run of 13 in a line of 15 must cover the middle 11 squares, wherever it starts.
- DOOR 7** Look for a brick whose two neighbours in the triangle are already known: a brick below = the brick above minus its partner.
- DOOR 8** Every symbol is either a piece of a # grid or a piece of an X. Match the shape first, then look for the dot.
- DOOR 9** Mark each clue in the chart with $\square$ for impossible and $\square$ for certain. When a row has four $\square$, the fifth square is certain.
- DOOR 10** Rows and columns with a 0 have no snowmen: rule them out first. A tree with only one free neighbour must have its snowman there.
- DOOR 11** A row or column with the number of the grid's width is full. Near A and B, the track has only a few ways to go.
- DOOR 12** Blocks with a 4, or with a 3 against an edge, force their lanterns at once. A 0 means no lanterns next to it.
- DOOR 13** Count the words of each length. A length with only one word tells you exactly where that word goes.
- DOOR 14** A 0 means all its neighbours are safe. Where a number has exactly as many hidden neighbours as its value, all of them are presents.
- DOOR 15** A 5 can never be smaller than anything, and a 1 can never be larger. Follow chains of signs: in $a < b < c$, a is at most 3.

- DOOR 16** The single dot is E and the single dash is T; the table shows the rest. Split each group at the spaces.
- DOOR 17** Rows and columns with a 0 are open snow. Put the three-square sleigh first: it only fits where a row or column number is 3 or more.
- DOOR 18** Start with the longest words and the rare letters (K, W, Y). Cross each word off the list and lightly shade its letters.
- DOOR 19** A 1 means the tallest chimney (5) is right next to that edge. A 5 means the chimneys rise 1, 2, 3, 4, 5 from that edge.
- DOOR 20** Find the smallest region first: its star has only a few places to go. Then rule out every square that touches a placed star.
- DOOR 21** Start with the biggest numbers. A run of 13 in a line of 15 must cover the middle 11 squares, wherever it starts.
- DOOR 22** Start with one-square tins and small cages with a large product or a big difference: they allow very few pairs.
- DOOR 23** Look for a row, column or box that already has most of its letters. The missing letters can often go in only one place.
- DOOR 24** A row or column with the number of the grid's width is full. Near A and B, the track has only a few ways to go.

ONE SOLID FACT TO START FROM

HINTS II: FOOTHOLDS



- DOOR 1** Mitten starts at row 3, column 1 and runs across to the right. The message begins THE KEY IS.
- DOOR 2** The shift is 3: every D stands for A, E for B, and so on. The first word, KDQJ, is HANG.
- DOOR 3** The smallest region has 2 squares; its star is at row 4, column 1.
- DOOR 4** The top row reads H E S L I G.
- DOOR 5** The route passes through row 9, column 10, roughly halfway along. The first letter you meet is T.
- DOOR 6** The picture is something you light when the power goes out. Row 13 is almost full.
- DOOR 7** The second brick from the left in the second row up is 33, and the far-left brick of the bottom row is 6.
- DOOR 8** The first two words are FROZEN DRIPS.
- DOOR 9** Ada is in Room 3.
- DOOR 10** The pine at row 1, column 2 has its snowman at row 1, column 1.
- DOOR 11** The track runs through row 4, column 1, row 4, column 2 and row 3, column 2 just after A.
- DOOR 12** There are lanterns at row 2, column 6 and at row 7, column 7.
- DOOR 13** Stocking goes in the slot that starts at row 2, column 7, reading down.
- DOOR 14** There are presents at row 1, column 2 and at row 6, column 5.
- DOOR 15** The top row reads 1 2 4 5 3.
- DOOR 16** The first word is NUTMEG.
- DOOR 17** The three-square sleigh covers row 5, column 7 to row 7, column 7.
- DOOR 18** Snowdrift starts at row 10, column 3 and runs upwards. The message begins THE KEY IS.
- DOOR 19** The top row reads 3 1 2 5 4.
- DOOR 20** The smallest region has 4 squares; its star is at row 8, column 8.
- DOOR 21** The picture hangs in a tower and rings. Row 12 is almost full.

DOOR 22 The top row reads 1 4 2 3 5.

DOOR 23 The top row reads K E R C T A F I U.

DOOR 24 The track runs through row 5, column 2, row 4, column 2 and row 3, column 2 just after A.

ALMOST THE ANSWER

HINTS III: LAST STEPS



- DOOR 1** The answer has 6 letters and begins TIN. The key letter is its 1st letter.
- DOOR 2** The answer has 5 letters and begins HO. The key letter is its 1st letter.
- DOOR 3** The answer has 6 letters and begins WRE. The key letter is its 3rd letter.
- DOOR 4** The answer has 6 letters and begins SLE. The key letter is its 1st letter.
- DOOR 5** The answer has 8 letters and begins TOBO. The key letter is its 1st letter.
- DOOR 6** The answer has 6 letters and begins CAN. The key letter is its 2nd letter.
- DOOR 7** The answer has 5 letters and begins FR. The key letter is its 2nd letter.
- DOOR 8** The answer has 6 letters and begins ICI. The key letter is its 1st letter.
- DOOR 9** The answer has 5 letters and begins SK. The key letter is its 1st letter.
- DOOR 10** The answer has 11 letters and begins GINGE. The key letter is its 2nd letter.
- DOOR 11** The answer has 4 letters and begins NO. The key letter is its 1st letter.
- DOOR 12** The answer has 7 letters and begins TWI. The key letter is its 1st letter.
- DOOR 13** The answer has 6 letters and begins HEA. The key letter is its 1st letter.
- DOOR 14** The answer has 8 letters and begins PRES. The key letter is its 3rd letter.
- DOOR 15** The answer has 6 letters and begins BAU. The key letter is its 5th letter.
- DOOR 16** The answer has 6 letters and begins EGG. The key letter is its 5th letter.
- DOOR 17** The answer has 10 letters and begins SNOWF. The key letter is its 8th letter.
- DOOR 18** The answer has 7 letters and begins LAN. The key letter is its 4th letter.
- DOOR 19** The answer has 6 letters and begins TOF. The key letter is its 2nd letter.
- DOOR 20** The answer has 8 letters and begins SNOW. The key letter is its 4th letter.

DOOR 21 The answer has 4 letters and begins BE. The key letter is its 2nd letter.

DOOR 22 The answer has 5 letters and begins ME. The key letter is its 3rd letter.

DOOR 23 The answer has 9 letters and begins FRUI. The key letter is its 6th letter.

DOOR 24 The answer has 12 letters and begins CHRIST. The key letter is its 1st letter.

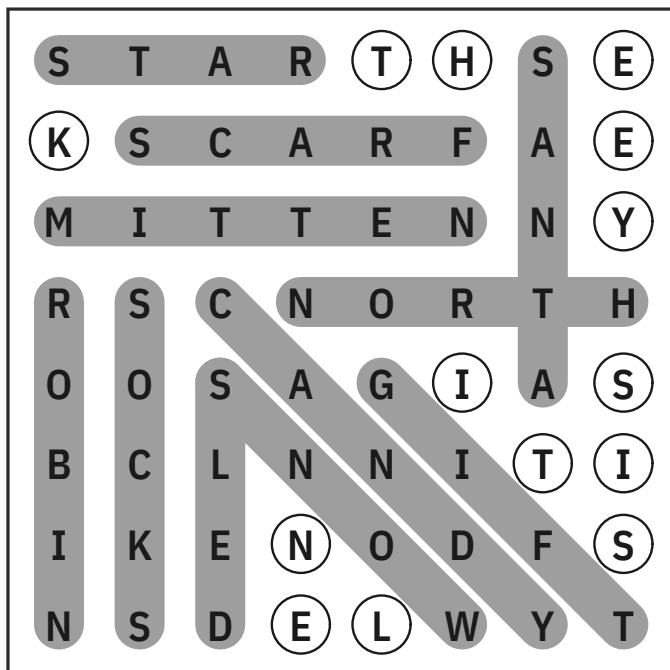
LOOK AWAY NOW IF YOU ARE STILL SOLVING

SOLUTIONS



DOOR ONE

Answer: TINSEL · key letter T



How it goes. With every word crossed out, the unused letters read THE KEY IS TINSEL. The key letter is the 1st letter, T.

DOOR TWO

Answer: HOLLY · key letter H

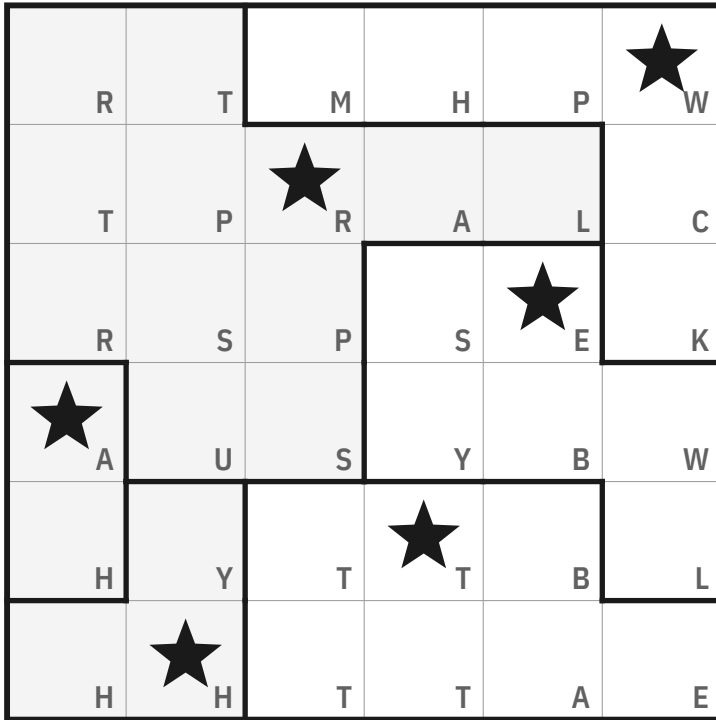
Shift each letter back by 3: D→A, E→B, F→C ...

**HANG THE GREEN LEAVES AND RED BERRIES ABOVE
EVERY DOOR. THE KEY IS HOLLY.**

How it goes. Shifting back by 3 turns KDQJ into HANG, and the whole message reads as above. The key letter is the 1st letter, **H**.

DOOR THREE

Answer: WREATH · key letter E



How it goes. Checkpoint: The smallest region has 2 squares; its star is at row 4, column 1. The stars, read row by row, sit on the letters W – R – E – A – T – H. The key letter is the 3rd letter, E.

DOOR FOUR

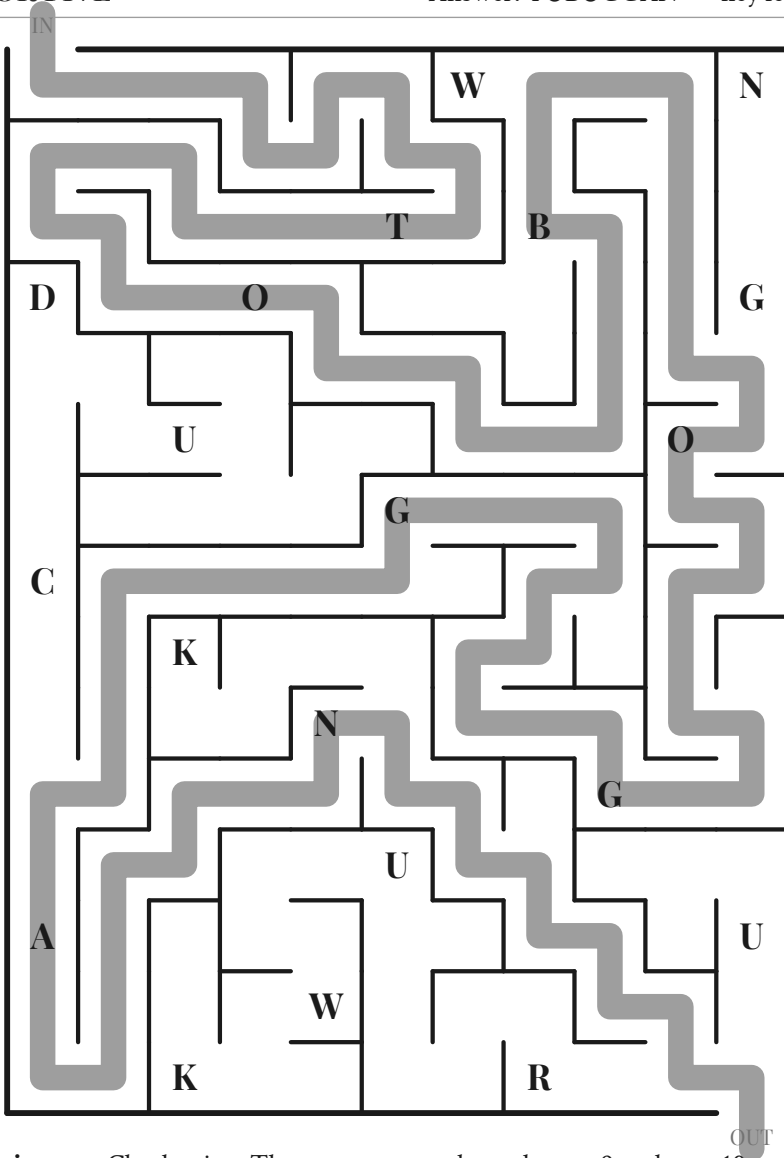
Answer: SLEIGH · key letter S

H	E	S	² L	I	G
I	G	L	S	H	³ E
L	⁶ H	E	⁵ G	S	I
S	I	G	E	L	H
E	¹ S	I	H	G	L
G	L	H	⁴ I	E	S

How it goes. Checkpoint: The top row reads H E S L I G. The numbered cells, in order, hold S – L – E – I – G – H. The key letter is the 1st letter, **S**.

DOOR FIVE

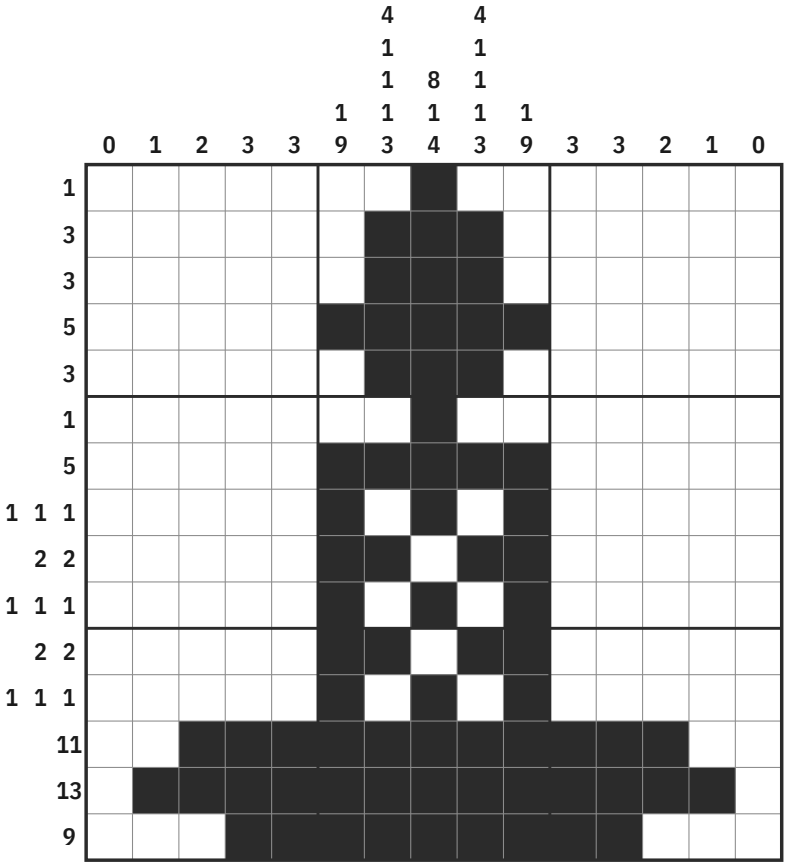
Answer: TOBOGGAN · key letter T



How it goes. Checkpoint: The route passes through row 9, column 10, roughly halfway along. The first letter you meet is T. The only route from IN to OUT passes the letters T – O – B – O – G – G – A – N, in that order; the other letters are all on dead ends. The key letter is the 1st letter, **T**.

DOOR SIX

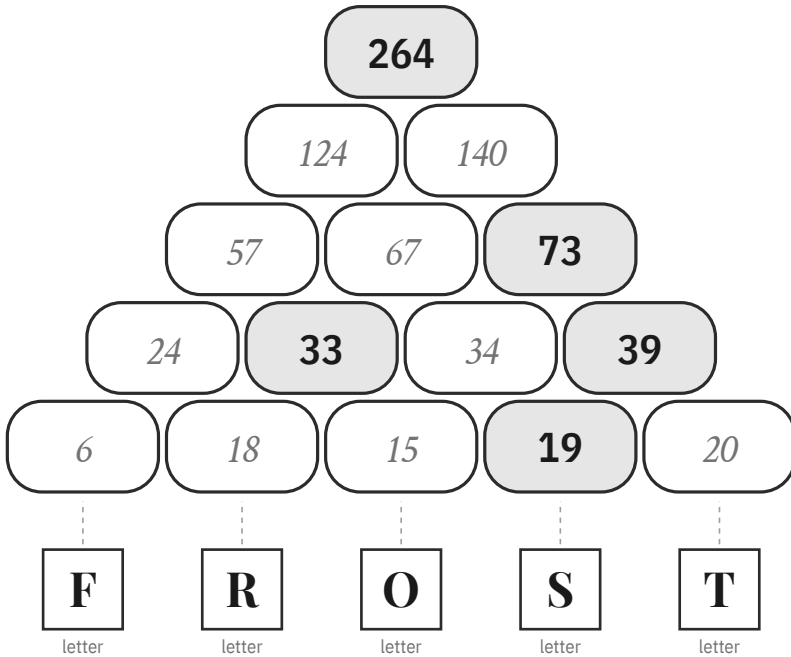
Answer: CANDLE · key letter A



How it goes. The picture is a candle. The key letter is the 2nd letter, A.

DOOR SEVEN

Answer: FROST · key letter R



How it goes. Checkpoint: The second brick from the left in the second row up is 33, and the far-left brick of the bottom row is 6. The bottom row is 6, 18, 15, 19, 20, which turns into F – R – O – S – T with A = 1, B = 2 and so on. The key letter is the 2nd letter, **R**.

DOOR EIGHT

Answer: ICICLE · key letter I

Using the key, the symbols read:

**FROZEN DRIPS HANG FROM THE EAVES. THE KEY IS
ICICLE.**

How it goes. Reading the symbols with the key gives the message above. The key letter is the 1st letter, **I**.

DOOR NINE

Answer: SKATE · key letter S

	Room 1	Room 2	Room 3	Room 4	Room 5	marshm.	cinnamon	cream	pepperm.	nutmeg	scarf	mittens	hat	socks	jumper
SAM	●							●			●				
KIT		●				●								●	
ADA			●							●			●		
TOM				●					●						●
EVE					●		●					●			

Room 1: Sam, whipped cream, scarf · Room 2: Kit, marshmallows, socks · Room 3: Ada, nutmeg, bobble hat · Room 4: Tom, peppermint, jumper · Room 5: Eve, cinnamon, mittens

How it goes. Checkpoint: Ada is in Room 3. Walking down the corridor from Room 1, the guests are Sam, Kit, Ada, Tom, Eve: S – K – A – T – E. The key letter is the 1st letter, **S**.

DOOR TEN

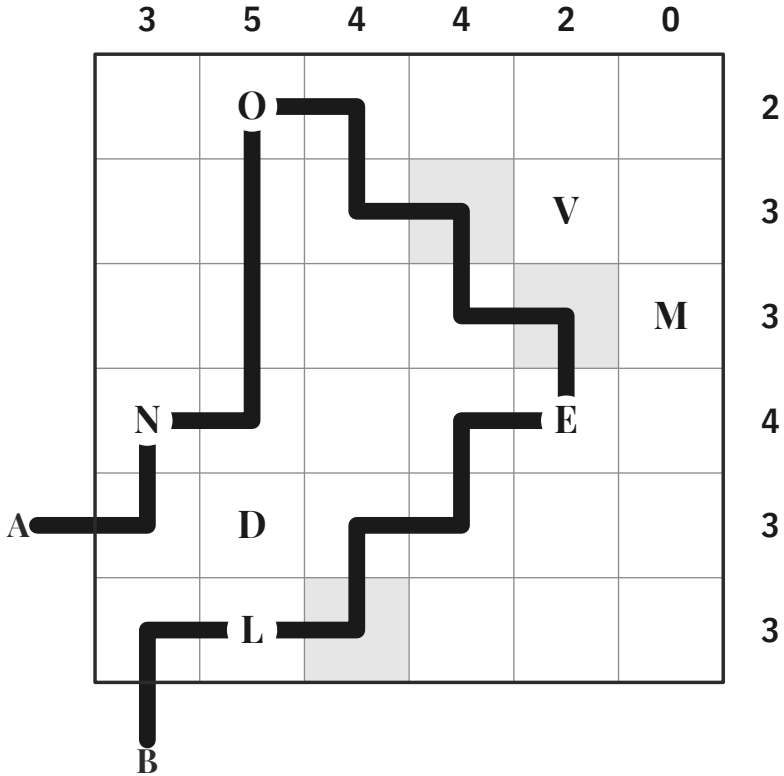
Answer: GINGERBREAD · key letter I

1	2	1	2	1	1	1	2		
 G		 I			C	O	O	O	2
F	E	O	G	D	S	W	S		0
M	I		 N	N	R	 G	M		2
S	 E	A	S	S	T		E		1
E		F	 R			D	A		1
W	A	C	T	B	 B	U	 R		2
B		G	H		H	Y			0
U	 E	H	S	 A	L		 D		3

How it goes. Checkpoint: The pine at row 1, column 2 has its snowman at row 1, column 1. Read row by row, the snowmen stand on G – I – N – G – E – R – B – R – E – A – D. The key letter is the 2nd letter, **I**.

DOOR ELEVEN

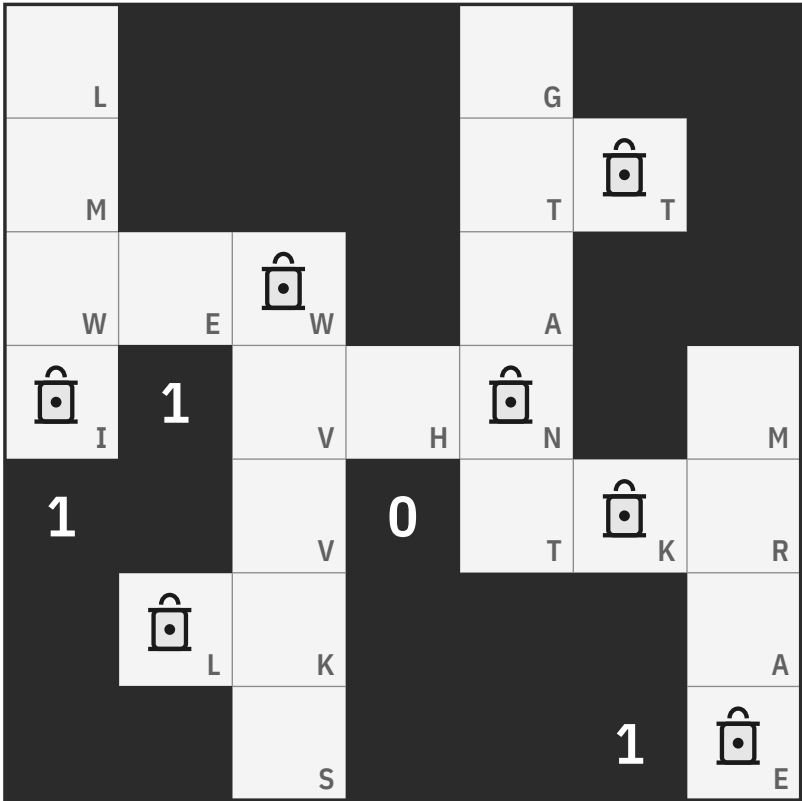
Answer: NOEL · key letter N



How it goes. Checkpoint: The track runs through row 4, column 1, row 4, column 2 and row 3, column 2 just after A. From A to B the track passes the letters N – O – E – L; the other letters are off the line. The key letter is the 1st letter, N.

DOOR TWELVE

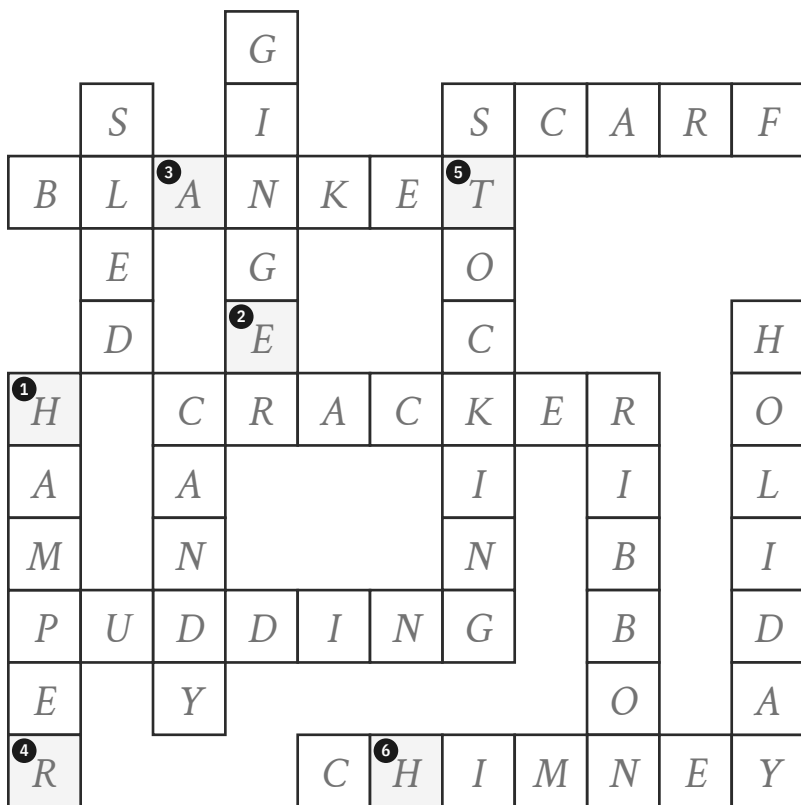
Answer: TWINKLE · key letter T



How it goes. Checkpoint: There are lanterns at row 2, column 6 and at row 7, column 7. Read row by row, the lanterns sit on T – W – I – N – K – L – E. The key letter is the 1st letter, T.

DOOR THIRTEEN

Answer: HEARTH · key letter H



How it goes. Checkpoint: Stocking goes in the slot that starts at row 2, column 7, reading down. The numbered circles, in order, hold H – E – A – R – T – H. The key letter is the 1st letter, **H**.

DOOR FOURTEEN

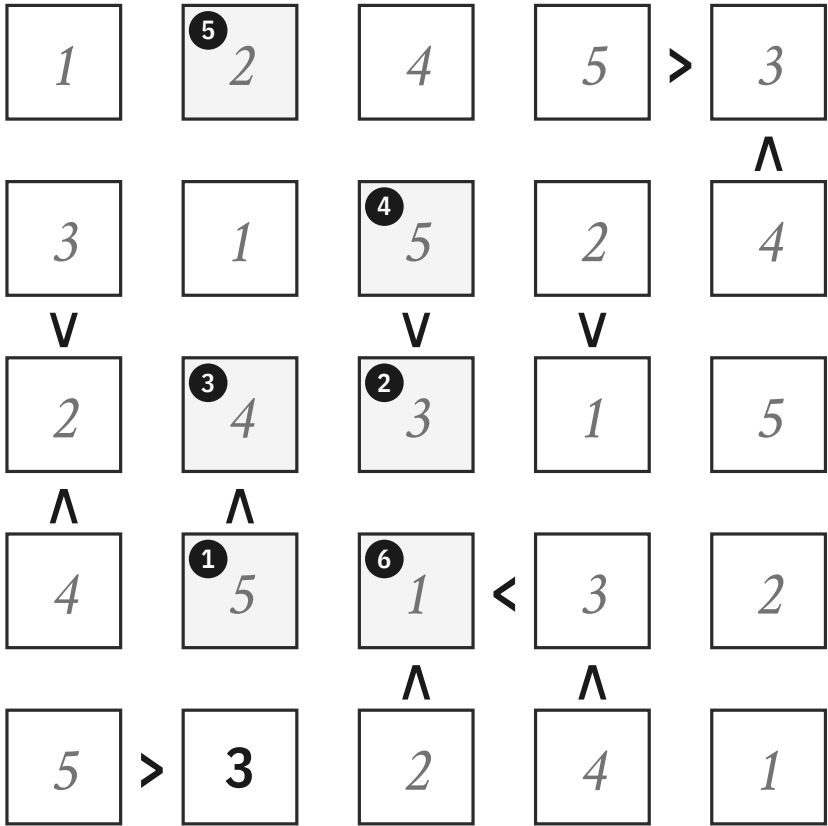
Answer: PRESENTS · key letter E

2	 P	2	2		B	O	O		
 R		V	 E	2	 S	1	R		
2	 E		U		R	D	1	G	
			H	1	1		M	0	
0		S	T	 N	2	1		B	
	I	P	 T		R	 S	S	O	
	C	1	1		T	1		F	0

How it goes. Checkpoint: There are presents at row 1, column 2 and at row 6, column 5. Read row by row, the presents are on P – R – E – S – E – N – T – S. The key letter is the 3rd letter, **E**.

DOOR FIFTEEN

Answer: BAUBLE · key letter L



How it goes. Checkpoint: The top row reads 1 2 4 5 3. With the key, the numbered cells spell B – A – U – B – L – E. The key letter is the 5th letter, **L**.

DOOR SIXTEEN

Answer: EGGNOG · key letter O

The bells ring out:

NUTMEG ON TOP. THE KEY IS EGGNOG.

How it goes. Splitting the rings at the spaces and looking each group up in the table gives the message above. The key letter is the 5th letter, **O**.

DOOR SEVENTEEN

Answer: SNOWFLAKES · key letter K

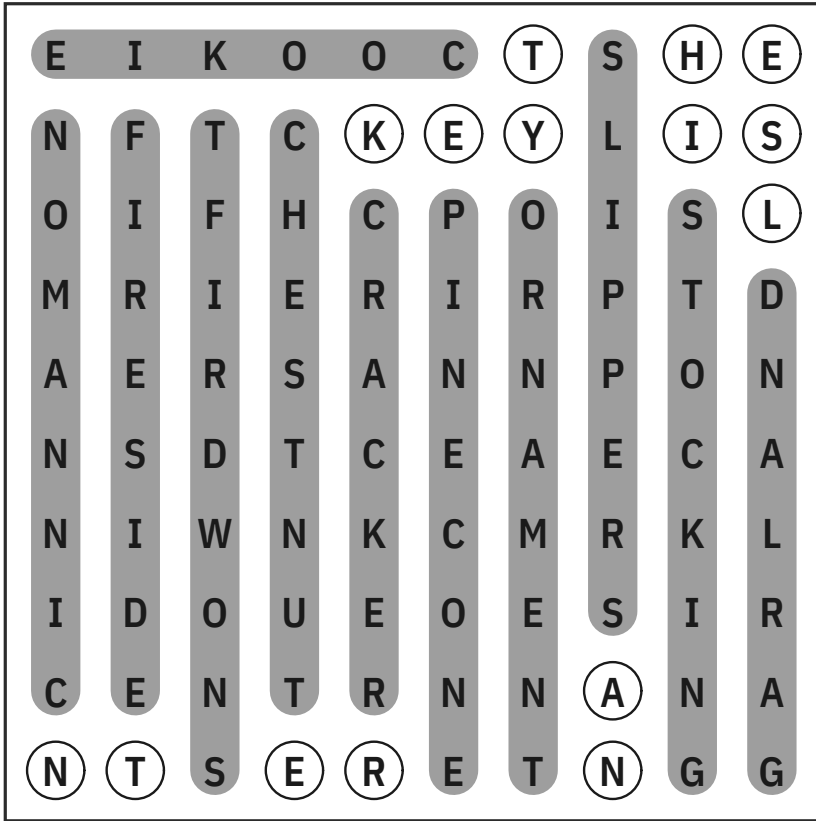
1	0	4	1	0	1	3	
 S	W	 N	 G	D	 M		2
D	K	I	A	Y	 O	R	1
S	W	O	V	R	U	L	0
I	T	 W	 F	C	R	C	2
W	P	I	P	E	S	 L	1
E	P	 A	I	E	U	 K	2
E	N	 E	N	K	D	 S	2

THE FLEET:      

How it goes. Checkpoint: The three-square sleigh covers row 5, column 7 to row 7, column 7. Read row by row, the sleighs and sleds cover S – N – O – W – F – L – A – K – E – S. The key letter is the 8th letter, **K**.

DOOR EIGHTEEN

Answer: LANTERN · key letter T



How it goes. With every word crossed out, the unused letters read THE KEY IS LANTERN. The key letter is the 4th letter, T.

DOOR NINETEEN

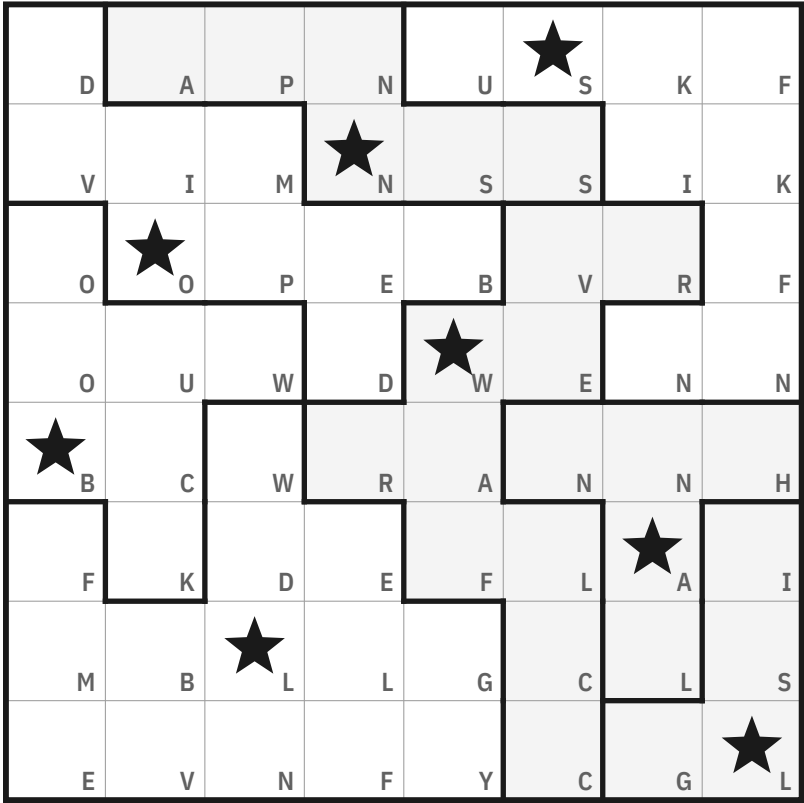
Answer: TOFFEE · key letter O

			3	1	2	
	3	1	5	2	4	2
	5	3	1	4	2	3
4	2	1	2	4	3	5
	4	1	5	3	2	1
3	2	3	4	5	1	3
			2			2

How it goes. Checkpoint: The top row reads 3 1 2 5 4. With the key, the numbered cells spell T – O – F – F – E – E. The key letter is the 2nd letter, **O**.

DOOR TWENTY

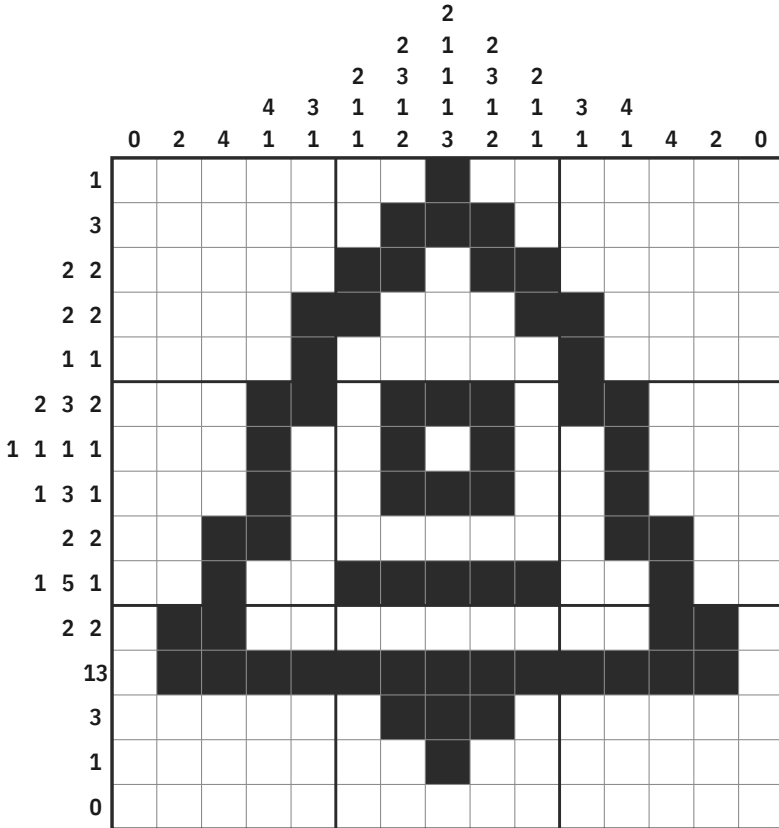
Answer: SNOWBALL · key letter W



How it goes. Checkpoint: The smallest region has 4 squares; its star is at row 8, column 8. The stars, read row by row, sit on the letters S – N – O – W – B – A – L – L. The key letter is the 4th letter, **W**.

DOOR TWENTY-ONE

Answer: BELL · key letter E



How it goes. The picture is a bell. The key letter is the 2nd letter, E.

DOOR TWENTY-TWO

Answer: MERRY · key letter R

¹ 1	^{20×} 4	^{2÷} 2	^{1−} 3	^{2−} 5
5	1	4	2	3 ⁴
⁹⁺ 3 ³	^{2×} 2	1	^{20×} 5	4 ⁵
2	^{2−} 5 ²	^{1−} 3	4	1
4	3	⁸⁺ 5	1 ¹	2

How it goes. Checkpoint: The top row reads 1 4 2 3 5. With the key, the numbered cells spell M – E – R – R – Y. The key letter is the 3rd letter, **R**.

DOOR TWENTY-THREE

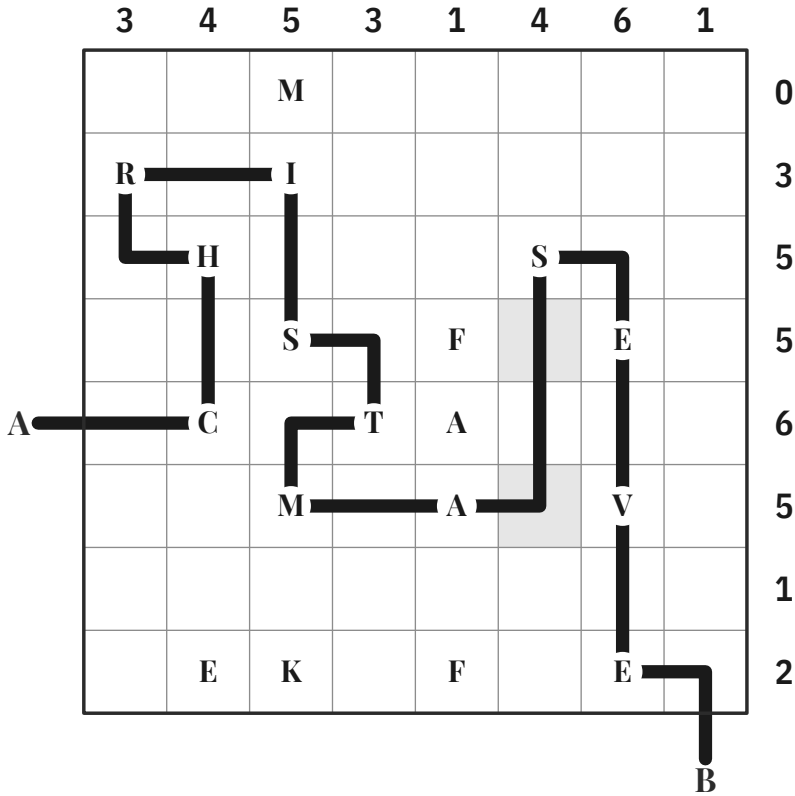
Answer: FRUITCAKE · key letter C

<i>K</i>	<i>E</i>	R	<i>C</i>	<i>T</i>	A	<i>F</i>	I	U
U	⁴ <i>I</i>	<i>F</i>	E	<i>K</i>	R	⁷ <i>A</i>	<i>C</i>	T
T	<i>C</i>	<i>A</i>	I	<i>U</i>	<i>F</i>	<i>R</i>	<i>E</i>	<i>K</i>
⁶ <i>C</i>	A	<i>U</i>	¹ <i>F</i>	<i>I</i>	K	<i>T</i>	R	⁹ <i>E</i>
I	<i>F</i>	K	R	<i>E</i>	<i>T</i>	U	A	C
<i>E</i>	<i>R</i>	T	<i>A</i>	<i>C</i>	<i>U</i>	⁸ <i>K</i>	<i>F</i>	I
<i>R</i>	⁵ <i>T</i>	<i>C</i>	<i>U</i>	<i>A</i>	I	<i>E</i>	K	F
<i>F</i>	K	E	<i>T</i>	² <i>R</i>	<i>C</i>	<i>I</i>	³ <i>U</i>	<i>A</i>
A	U	I	K	F	<i>E</i>	<i>C</i>	T	<i>R</i>

How it goes. Checkpoint: The top row reads K E R C T A F I U. The numbered cells, in order, hold F – R – U – I – T – C – A – K – E. The key letter is the 6th letter, C.

DOOR TWENTY-FOUR

Answer: CHRISTMASEVE · key letter C



How it goes. Checkpoint: The track runs through row 5, column 2, row 4, column 2 and row 3, column 2 just after A. From A to B the track passes the letters C – H – R – I – S – T – M – A – S – E – V – E; the other letters are off the line. The key letter is the 1st letter, C.

THANK YOU

THANK YOU FOR SOLVING



I hope the Great Advent Clock kept you good company through December. If you enjoyed it, a short review on Amazon helps other puzzlers find the book, and it means a great deal to a small, independent author.

If you think you have found a mistake, please check the solution pages first: every puzzle in this book was re-solved by a separate program and has exactly one answer.

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